

set foot on fragrant Olympus or allow fruit to sprout from the earth until she saw with her own eyes her lovely daughter. (324–333)

Then loud-thundering Zeus, who sees all, sent the slayer of Argus, Hermes, with his golden wand to Erebus to appeal to Hades with gentle words and bring chaste Persephone up from the murky depths to the light, so that her mother might desist from anger when she saw her daughter with her own eyes. Hermes did not disobey, and straightway he left the realms of Olympus and swiftly rushed down to the depths of the earth. He encountered the lord Hades within his house, sitting on a couch with his modest wife, who was very reluctant because of her longing for her mother. And Demeter, far away, brooded over her designs to thwart the actions of the blessed gods. (334–345)

The mighty slayer of Argus stood near and said: “Hades of the dark hair, ruler of the dead, father Zeus has ordered me to bring to him from Erebus august Persephone, so that her mother may see her with her own eyes and desist from her wrath and dread anger against the immortals. For she is devising a great scheme to destroy the feeble tribes of earthborn men by keeping the seed hidden under earth and ruining the honors that are bestowed on the immortals. She clings to her dire wrath and does not associate with the gods but remains on the rocky citadel of Eleusis sitting apart within her fragrant temple.” (346–357)

Thus he spoke. And Hades, the lord of those below, smiled with furrowed brows and did not disobey the commands of Zeus the king; and he hastily ordered wise Persephone: “Go, Persephone, to the side of your dark-robed mother, with a gentle and loving heart in your breast. Be not distraught. I among the immortals shall not be an unworthy husband for you, since I am the full brother of your father, Zeus. While you are here with me you will rule over all that lives and moves, and you will hold the greatest honors among the immortals. Those who wrong you and do not propitiate your power by performing holy rites and sacrifices and offering appropriate gifts will find eternal retribution.” (357–369)

Thus he spoke. And wise Persephone was delighted and jumped up quickly in her joy. But her husband secretly gave her the honey-sweet fruit of the pomegranate to eat, taking thought for himself that she should not remain all her days above with august, dark-robed Demeter. Hades, host of many, then yoked his immortal horses to the front of his golden chariot, which Persephone mounted; the mighty slayer of Argus, Hermes, took the reins and whip in his hands and drove them up and away from the palace; the pair of horses readily sped along and easily covered their long journey. Neither the sea nor streams of rivers nor grassy glens nor mountaintops impeded the onrush of the immortal horses as they cut through the deep air above them in their course. The charioteer brought them to a halt in front of the fragrant temple where Demeter of the lovely crown waited. (370–385)

DEMETER'S ECSTATIC REUNION WITH PERSEPHONE

At the sight of her daughter, she rushed out like a maenad down a mountain thick with woods. When Persephone on the other side saw the beautiful eyes of her mother, she leaped down from the chariot with its horses and ran, throwing her arms about her neck in an embrace. But while Demeter still had her dear child in her arms, suddenly her heart sensed some treachery; trembling with dread she let go her loving embrace and asked quickly: “My child, have you eaten any food while you were below? Speak up, do not hide anything so

that we both may know. If you have not, even though you have been in the company of loathsome Hades, you will live with me and your father, Zeus the cloud-gatherer, son of Cronus, in honor among all the immortals. But if you have eaten anything, you will return again beneath the depths of the earth and live there a third part of each year; the other two-thirds of the time you will spend with me and the other immortals. When the spring blooms with all sorts of sweet-smelling flowers, then again you will rise from the gloomy region below, a great wonder for gods and mortals. But tell me, too, by what trick the strong host of many deceived you?" (385–404) 310

The very beautiful Persephone then said in answer: "To be sure, mother, I shall tell you the whole truth. When Hermes, the bringer of luck and swift messenger, came from my father, the son of Cronus, and the other gods of the sky, saying that I was to come up from Erebus in order that you might see me with your own eyes and desist from your wrath and dread anger against the immortals, I immediately jumped up in my joy. But Hades swiftly put in my mouth the fruit of the pomegranate, a honey-sweet morsel, and compelled me to eat it by force against my will. I shall tell you too how he came and carried me down to the depths of the earth through the shrewd plan of my father, the son of Cronus, going through it all as you ask. (405–416) 320

"We were all playing in a lovely meadow: Leucippe, Phaeno, Electra, Ianche, Melite, Iache, Rhodeia, Callirhoë, Melobosis, Tyche, Ocyrhoë beautiful as a flower, Chryseïs, Ianeira, Acaste, Admete, Rhodope, Pluto, lovely Calypso, Styx and Urania, charming Galaxaura,² and Pallas the battle-rouser and Artemis delighting in arrows. (417–424)

"We were playing and gathering lovely flowers in our hands, a mixed array of soft crocuses, irises, hyacinths, roses in full bloom, and lilies, wonderful to behold, and a narcissus, which the wide earth produced, in color yellow of a crocus. I plucked it joyously, but the earth beneath opened wide and thereupon the mighty lord, the host of many, leaped up and carried me away in his golden chariot beneath the earth despite my violent protests—my cries were loud and shrill. I tell you the whole truth, although the story gives me pain." (425–433) 330

Thus they then in mutual love and tender embraces greatly cheered each other's heart and soul the whole long day. Their grief was assuaged as they exchanged their joys. Hecate, her hair brilliantly arrayed, approached them and frequently embraced the holy daughter of Demeter. From that time on, regal Hecate became the lady and attendant of Persephone. (434–440)

DEMETER RESTORES FERTILITY AND ESTABLISHES THE MYSTERIES

Loud-thundering Zeus, who sees far and wide, sent as a messenger to them Rhea of the lovely hair to lead dark-robed Demeter among the company of the gods, and he promised to grant her the honors that she would choose among the immortal gods, and he consented that her daughter live a third part of the revolving year in the gloomy depths below and the other two-thirds by the side of her mother and the other immortals. Thus he ordered, and the goddess Rhea did not disobey the message of Zeus. She quickly rushed down from the heights of Olympus and came to the Rharian plain, previously very fertile, but now not fertile at all, standing leafless and barren. The white seed was hidden through the machinations of Demeter of the lovely ankles. But soon thereafter, with the burgeoning of spring, long ears of grain would be luxuriant, and the rich furrows 340 360



Audio



Hades and Persephone. Terra-cotta plaque, ca. 460 B.C.; height 10 $\frac{1}{4}$ in. This is one of a series of small votive reliefs from the sanctuary of Persephone at Locri (in southern Italy). The divinities of the Underworld sit enthroned holding emblems connected with their worship—grain, parsley, a cock, a bowl. In front stands a lamp with a tiny cock on it, and another cock stands beneath Persephone's throne. (*Scala/Art Resource, NY*)

too along the ground would be laden with grain, some already bound in sheaves. (441–456)

Rhea came from the barren air to this place first of all, and the goddesses beheld each other gladly and rejoiced in their hearts. Rhea, her hair brilliantly arrayed, spoke to Demeter thus: “Come here, my daughter; loud-thundering Zeus, who sees far and wide, summons you to join the company of the gods, and he has promised to grant you whatever honors you would like among the immortals, and he has consented that your daughter live a third part of the revolving year in the gloomy depths below and the other two-thirds with you and the other gods. Thus he said it would be accomplished and nodded his head in assent. But come, my child, and be obedient; do not persist in your relentless anger against Zeus, the dark-clouded son of Cronus. But quickly make grow for human beings the life-bringing fruit in abundance.” (457–469)

Thus she spoke, and Demeter of the lovely crown obeyed. Quickly, she caused fruit to spring up from the fertile plains, and the whole wide land was laden with leaves and flowers. She went to the kings who minister justice (Triptolemus, Diocles, the rider of horses, the mighty Eumolpus, and Celeus, the leader of the people) and showed them the performance of her holy rites and taught her mysteries to them all, Triptolemus and Polyxeinus and Diocles besides—holy mysteries that one may not by any means violate or question or express. For the great reverence due to the gods restrains one's voice.

Happy is the one of mortals on earth who has seen these things. But those who are uninitiated into the holy rites and have no part never are destined to a similar joy when they are dead in the gloomy realm below. (470–482)

But when the goddess of goddesses had ordained all these things, they made their way to Olympus among the company of the other gods. There they dwell beside Zeus, who delights in the thunder, august and holy goddesses. Greatly

happy is the one of mortals on earth whom they dearly love; straightway they send, as a guest to his great house, Plutus, who gives wealth to human beings. (483–489)

Come now you who hold power over the land of fragrant Eleusis, sea-girt Paros, and rocky Antron, lady and queen Demeter, the giver of good things in season, both yourself and your daughter, very beautiful Persephone, kindly grant me a pleasing substance in reward for my song. Yet I shall remember both you and another song too. (490–495)

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Interpretations of the Hymn

The myth of Demeter and Persephone represents another variation of a fundamental and recurring theme—the death and rebirth of vegetation as a metaphor or allegory for spiritual resurrection. In the New Testament (John 12:24), this archetype is expressed in this way: “Unless a grain of wheat falls into the earth and dies, it remains alone; but if it dies it bears much fruit.” In this Greek hymn, the allegory is rendered in terms of the touching emotions of mother and daughter; more often the symbols and metaphors involve the relationship between a fertility goddess and her male partner, either lover or son (e.g., Aphrodite and Adonis, Cybele and Attis, Semele and Dionysus). Demeter is often imagined as the goddess of the ripe grain; Persephone then is the deity of the budding tender shoots. They are invoked together as the “two goddesses.” Persephone (who is often called merely *Kore*, a name meaning “girl”) is the daughter of Demeter and Zeus, who enact once again the sacred marriage between earth-goddess and sky-god.

This is a hymn permeated by emotional longings and religious allegories about death and rebirth, resurrection, and salvation. The parable of the infant **Demophoön** is particularly revealing. Nursed and cherished by Demeter, he flourished like a god and would have become immortal, his impure mortality cleansed away in the fire, if only the unfortunate Metaneira, who did not understand the rituals, had not interfered. If we are nourished like this child by Demeter’s truth and become initiated into her mysteries, we too shall find redemption, immortality, and joy through the same love and devotion of this holy mother, lavished not only upon Demophoön but also her lovely daughter.

The *Homeric Hymn to Demeter* also illustrates the grim character of Hades in his method of obtaining a wife and provides the mythological reasons for Hecate’s



Persephone, Hermes, and Hecate. Athenian red-figure krater, ca. 440 B.C. Persephone emerges from the Underworld under the protection of Hermes *psychopompos*, who looks directly at the viewer. He is dressed as a traveler and wears the *petasus* and *chlamys* (traveler's cloak), while the caduceus in his left hand points toward the ground. To the right Hecate, looking back at Persephone and with a torch in each hand, lights the way. (Image copyright © The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art Resource, NY)

prominence as a goddess of the Underworld. Hades' basic character as a fertility god is evident from the location of his realm, the violence of his nature, and his link with horses. He is thus a god of agricultural wealth (compare his names, Pluto or Dis, among the Romans); but he should not be confused with Plutus (Wealth) mentioned in the last lines of the hymn, another deity of agricultural plenty and prosperity (and thus wealth in general), the offspring of Demeter and Iasion.



Triptolemus

Triptolemus, who also appears in the concluding lines of the hymn, is generally depicted as the messenger of Demeter when she restored fertility to the ground. He is the one who taught and spread her arts of agriculture to new lands at that time and later, often traveling in a magical car drawn by winged dragons, a gift of Demeter. He is sometimes either merged in identity with the infant Demophoön (variant spelling is Demophon) of the hymn or said to be his brother; in Plato, Triptolemus is a judge of the dead.

The Eleusinian Mysteries

This hymn to Demeter is of major importance because it provides the most significant evidence that we have for the nature of the worship of Demeter at **Eleusis**. The town of Eleusis is about 14 miles west of Athens; the religion and ceremony that developed in honor of Demeter and her daughter had its center here, but the city of Athens, too, was intimately involved. This religious observance was of a special kind, not the general prerogative of everyone but open only to those who wished to become initiates. These devotees were sworn to absolute secrecy and faced dire punishments if they revealed the secret rites.³ This does not imply that initiation was confined to a select few. In early times, membership was inevitably limited to the people of Eleusis and Athens; but soon participants came from all areas of the Hellenic world and eventually from the Roman Empire as well.

This worship of Demeter was not restricted to men; women, children, and even slaves could participate. Appropriately, the religious celebration that evolved was given the name of the Eleusinian mysteries. Demeter, then, along with other Hellenic deities, is the inspiration for a kind of worship that is generally designated as the mystery religions (compare elements in the worship of Dionysus and aspects of the devotion to Aphrodite and Adonis or Cybele and Attis). Orpheus is credited with originating the mysteries, and the nature of Orphism and kindred mystery religions will be considered in Chapter 16. Although there must have been differences among the various mystery religions (some of them probably quite marked) obvious to the ancient world, today we have difficulty distinguishing precisely among them. It seems certain that the major common denominator is a belief in the immortality of the soul and a future life.

The Departure of Triptolemus. Attic red-figure cup by Makron, ca. 480 B.C.; height 8 ¼ in. Triptolemus holds stalks of grain in his left hand and in his right hand a dish (*phiale*), into which Persephone pours liquid from the jug in her right hand; she holds a torch in her left hand. The libation is a necessary ritual before departure on a journey. To the left stands Demeter, holding a torch and grain-stalks, and the personification of Eleusis stands behind Persephone. Triptolemus sits in a throne-like wheeled vehicle, whose wings symbolize the speed and extent of his travels, while the serpent indicates his association with the grain-bearing earth. (© The Trustees of the British Museum)

The mysteries at Eleusis were kept secret so successfully that scholars are by no means agreed about what can be said with any certainty, particularly about the highest and most profound elements of the worship. The sanctuary at Eleusis has been excavated,⁴ and buildings connected with the ceremonies have been found; most important among them is the temple of Demeter, where the final revelation of the mysteries was celebrated.⁵ But no evidence has been unearthed that might dispel the secrecy with absolute certainty once and for all. The priests in charge of the rites presumably transmitted orally what Demeter was said to have taught.

It is impossible to know just how much of the ritual is revealed in the *Hymn to Demeter*. It would be presumptuous to imagine that the most profound secrets are here for all to read, and we cannot be sure how much may be inferred from what is directly stated. That elements of the ceremonies are indicated cannot be denied, but presumably these are only the elements that were witnessed or revealed to all, not only to the initiated. Thus the text prescribes such details as an interval of nine days, fasting, the carrying of torches, the exchange of jests, the partaking of the drink **Kykeon**, the wearing of a special dress (e.g., the veil of Demeter); even precise geographical indications (e.g., the Maiden Well and the site of the temple) are designated.

The emotional tone of the poem, too, might hold the key for a mystic performance in connection with the celebrations. The anguish of Demeter, her frantic wanderings and search, the traumatic episode with Demophoön, the miraculous transformation of the goddess, the thrilling reunion between mother and daughter, the blessed return of vegetation to a barren earth—these are some of the obvious emotional and dramatic highlights.

The Greater and Lesser Mysteries

On the basis of our inadequate evidence, we present the following tentative outline of basic procedures in the celebration of the Eleusinian mysteries; ultimate revelation and meaning are matters of more tenuous conjecture. Two major compulsory stages had to be undertaken: (1) participation in the Lesser Mysteries, involving preliminary steps in initiation; (2) advancement to the Greater Mysteries, which entailed full initiation into the cult. A third stage, not required but possible, entailed participation in the highest rites.⁶ It is immediately apparent that these mysteries are basically different from the festivals celebrated in the Panhellenic sanctuaries at Olympia and Delphi, which were open to all, without secrecy or initiation or a fundamental mystic philosophy, however religious the tone that oracular response and devotion to a god might set.

Two major priestly families were connected with Eleusis.⁷ Among the many important priesthoods and assistant officials, the highest was that of the **Hierophant**. This priest alone could reveal to the worshipers the ultimate mysteries that entailed the showing of the **Hiera**, the sacred objects—his title means “he who reveals the Hiera.” Prominent too was the priestess of Demeter, who lived in a sacred house. Many of the priests received a fixed sum of money from each initiate as a fee for their services. The initiate was sponsored and directed by a patron.⁸

The Lesser Mysteries were held in Athens, usually once a year in early spring. Precise details are unknown, but the general purpose was certainly the preliminary preparation of the initiates for subsequent advancement to higher things.

Ceremonies probably focused on ritual purification, involving sacrifices, prayer, fasting, and cleansing by water.

The Greater Mysteries were held annually during the months of September and October. A holy truce was declared for a period of fifty-five days, and heralds were sent to issue invitations to states. Both Athens and Eleusis were involved in the festivities. Preliminary to the festival proper was the day on which the *Hiera* were taken out of the temple of Demeter in Eleusis and brought to Athens amid great pomp and ceremony. The splendid procession, headed by the priests and priestesses who carried the *Hiera* in sacred caskets bound by ribbons, was met officially in Athens and escorted in state to the sanctuary of Demeter in the city (the Eleusinion). The next day began the formal celebration of the Greater Mysteries, which continued through eight days, the ceremonies culminating in Eleusis, with a return to Athens on the ninth. The first day saw the people summoned to an assembly in the Athenian agora; those who were pure and knew Greek were invited by proclamation to participate in the mysteries. On the second day, all participants were ordered to cleanse themselves in the sea. The third day was devoted to sacrifices and prayers. The fourth day was spent honoring the god of healing, Asclepius, who according to tradition had in previous times arrived late for initiation. So on this day other latecomers could enroll.

The festivities in Athens culminated on the fifth day in a brilliant procession back to Eleusis. Priests and laymen wended their prescribed way, crowned with myrtle and carrying mystic branches of myrtle tied with wool strands.⁹ Heading the procession was a wooden statue of *Iacchus* (very likely another name for the god *Dionysus*) escorted in a carriage. At some stages of the journey, abuse, jest, and insults in scurrilous language were exchanged, perhaps in part to instill humility in the throng. Prayers were chanted and hymns sung; torches were carried and lit as night fell, and the sacred procession reached the sanctuary of Demeter in Eleusis.

The sixth and seventh days brought the initiates to the secret core of the mysteries, and it seems safe to assume that much of the ritual was performed in remembrance of the episodes described in the *Hymn to Demeter*. Thus there was a fast (certain foods, such as pomegranates and beans, were prohibited) and a vigil; the fast was probably ended by the drinking of the prescribed drink, the *Kykeon*, whatever its significance.

Conjectures about the Revelation

The heart of the ceremonies, which were celebrated in Demeter's temple, apparently involved three stages: a dramatic enactment, the revelation of sacred objects, and the uttering of certain words. What were the themes of the dramatic pageant? Probably it focused on incidents from the story of Demeter and her wanderings and other episodes recorded in the hymn, all designed to elicit a religious catharsis. Some have suggested scenes of an Orphic character involving a simulated trip to the Underworld, with fabricated apparitions of terror and sublimity as the action moved from Hell (Tartarus) to Paradise (Elysium). That no underground chambers have been found in the excavations does not necessarily invalidate this theory. We do not know whether the initiates merely witnessed the drama or actually participated in it. Eventually, the culmination was the awe-inspiring exhibition by the Hierophant himself of the holy objects, bathed in a

The Niinnion Pinax and the Celebration of the Mysteries at Eleusis

This clay tablet is a *pinax* (a votive plaque set up in a sanctuary to honor a god or goddess). This particular pinax has the name of the woman who dedicated it, Niinnion, inscribed along the bottom, and indicates that it was dedicated to “the two goddesses,” Demeter and Persephone. It is in the shape of a temple with a pediment. It was discovered, broken into nine pieces, at Eleusis in 1895. It is now in the National Archaeological Museum in Athens.

There are many questions about what this plaque is intended to illustrate: does it represent the celebration of the mysteries or another festival associated with Attica and Eleusis? Who precisely are the individual figures, and what are the other objects in the scene? Does it represent one single, discrete incident in a ritual, or is it a composite? Although absolute certainty is elusive, the plaque remains a provocative and compelling reminder of how difficult it can be to interpret a work that is so highly allusive and suggestive.

The great majority of scholars interpret the plaque as representing scenes associated with the mysteries. The column in the upper left corner may indicate

Niinnion Pinax. Red-figure clay votive tablet, ca. 370 B.C.; height: 0.44 m.; width: 0.32 m. (akg/De Agostini Picture Library)



Closer Look



that we are within a sanctuary. A thin, white line curls through the center of the plaque and might indicate that the figures are to be understood as representing two groups. Perhaps the scene is depicting two processions, with the one in the upper part of the panel being the procession during the celebration of the Greater Mysteries and the one in the lower part of the panel being the procession of the Lesser Mysteries.

The lower scene, starting from the left, shows a mature, bearded male, crowned in myrtle and carrying over his shoulder a staff, which has a pouch tied to it. A woman precedes him, holding a staff with a pouch in one hand and a sprig of myrtle in the other. Myrtle had sacred associations in the rites of both Demeter and Dionysus. The gesture she makes signifies an attitude of reverence or adoration. This woman has been identified by some as Niinnion herself, taking part in the procession from Athens to Eleusis in preparation for the celebration of the Greater Mysteries proper. Upon her head she is carrying a *kernos* (a sacred vessel for offerings), which was used in the rites of Eleusis. The *Kernophoria* (Bearing of the Kerno) was indeed part of the Greater and Lesser Mysteries. She stands on her toes and appears to be dancing. In front of her stands a figure, whose size seems to indicate that he is not a mortal but a god. He, too, wears a myrtle wreath upon his head and is leading the two *mystai* (initiates). He carries two torches, one pointed up and the other down. This may suggest the divergent existence of Persephone in the upper and lower worlds. This figure has been identified as Iacchus, an avatar of Dionysus, who is associated with the Mysteries of Eleusis. During the procession to Eleusis, preceded by a statue of Iacchus, the initiates would utter the cry "Iacche! Iacche!" signaling their excitement and anticipation. The figures in the lower panel make their procession to a seated goddess, who has been identified as Demeter. She is holding a *phiale* (libation vessel) and a staff. Between Iacchus and Demeter are depicted objects associated with Eleusis. The two crossing rods may be *bacchoi*, the sacred wands carried in the torch-lit procession to Eleusis. The white semicircular object is a bit harder to explain. Scholars have variously interpreted it: an *omphalos* (navel-stone); the rock left exposed within the *anaktoron* (the enclosed structure within the Telesterion); the *pelanos* (sacred cake offering of barley and wheat); or perhaps the *kiste* (covered basket), symbolizing the secrecy at the heart of the ritual.

In the upper register, from the left, we see a bearded male, crowned with a myrtle wreath and holding two sprigs of myrtle (the same man as below?); a garlanded youth who holds a cup in one hand and a staff in the other; and another woman bearing a *kernos* on her head. This woman has also been identified as Niinnion, depicted at a different moment in the ritual. A much larger figure, a goddess, precedes her, bearing torches, both of which point upward. Some have taken her to be Persephone leading the initiates toward her mother, Demeter, who is seated and holding a scepter. Others have understood the torch-bearing woman to be Hecate, who would certainly not be out of place in the scene. The coloring of the seated goddess is problematic. All the other female figures, whether mortal or divine, are depicted in white. Might she be Persephone, darkened to represent her chthonic existence?

The triangular pediment depicts the *Pannychis*, the nighttime celebration that followed the arrival of the initiates in Eleusis.

radiant light as he delivered his mystic utterances. The highest stage of all, which was not required for full initiation, entailed further revelation of some sort. The eighth day concluded the ceremonies; the ninth brought the return to Athens, this time with no organized procession. The following day the Athenian council heard a full report on the conduct of the ceremonies.

Conjectures about the exact nature of the highest mysteries have been legion. Comments by the fathers of the Christian church have been brought to witness, but their testimony has been rightly viewed with grave suspicion because it was probably rooted in prejudice, stemming from ignorance and hostility. No one of them had ever been initiated into the mysteries, and surprisingly enough, those Christian converts who had been initiated seem to have continued to take their pledges of secrecy very seriously. It has been claimed that the ultimate revelation was connected with the transformation of the Eleusinian plain into a field of golden grain (as in the hymn). The heart of the mysteries consisted of no more than showing an ear of grain to the worshipers. Thus we actually *do* know the secrets; or, if you like, they are really not worth knowing at all in terms of serious religious thought. Yet this ear of grain may, after all, realistically and allegorically represent the enigma of the mystery itself. Others insist on an enactment of the holy marriage in connection with the ceremonies, imagining not a spiritual but a literal sexual union between the Hierophant and the Priestess of Demeter. The Hieria too might be a representation of the female genitalia and, since Dionysus may be linked with Demeter and Kore, the male phallus as well. These holy objects were witnessed, or even manipulated, by the initiates in the course of the ritual. But there is no good evidence to argue with any certainty for such orgiastic procedures. The Hieria, as has been conjectured, could have been merely sacred and antique relics handed down from the Mycenaean Age.

It is difficult to agree with those who assert that Dionysus was completely excluded from the worship of Demeter at Eleusis. Iacchus has good claims to be

The Festival of the Thesmophoria

Women generally played a dominant role in the religion of the ancient world. Only women were permitted to participate in the celebration of some of these rites, and not only men but also virgins and children were excluded. One of the most famous of these women's festivals was the Thesmophoria, common to all Greece. The rites as performed in Athens became the subject of Aristophanes' comedy *Thesmophoriazusae*, which focused on the doings of the feminine participants and the dire consequences for any male who dared to intrude. The festival, lasting five days, took place in the fall, and its purpose was to ensure fertility, especially that of the crops to be sowed. Important in the ceremonies was the throwing of piglets into subterranean pits; after three days, their remains were recovered and mixed with the seed to be planted in hopes of a good harvest. The etiology for this practice was provided by the myth of Eubouleus, a swineherd, who was swallowed up with his swine by the earth at the very time Persephone was taken by Pluto. Celebrations also included sexual abstinence, a procession, sacrifices, fasting and feasting, and even ribald jests.¹⁰

Dionysus. And the myth of Zagreus-Dionysus, which provides the authority for Orphism (see pp. 322 and 390), makes Persephone his mother. Any spiritual message in the cult at Eleusis must have, in common with Dionysiac cults, a belief in the immortality of the soul and in redemption. If a doctrine similar to that of Orphism is also involved, it need not spring directly from Orphism. The confusion arises because all the mystery religions (whatever their precise interrelation)¹¹ did in fact preach certain things in common.

The death and rebirth of vegetation as deified in Demeter and Kore surely suggest a belief in the afterlife. After all, this is the promise of the hymn: "But the one who is not initiated into the holy rites and has no part never is destined to a similar joy when he is dead in the gloomy realm below." If at some future time, only obscure evidence remained for the ritual of the Christian Mass, scholars might imagine all sorts of things and miss completely the religious and spiritual doctrine on which it rests. The words uttered by the Hierophant could have ordained spiritual direction and hope. But there was no church body as such for the followers of Demeter, in the sense that they were required to return each year; we know of no sacred writings like those, say, of Orphism. George Mylonas' conclusions affirm the universal power of the matriarchal cult of Demeter in the Graeco-Roman world:

Whatever the substance and meaning of the Mysteries was, the fact remains that the cult of Eleusis satisfied the most sincere yearnings and the deepest longings of the human heart. The initiates returned from their pilgrimage to Eleusis full of joy and happiness, with the fear of death diminished and the strengthened hope of a better life in the world of shadows: "Thrice happy are those of mortals, who having seen those rites depart for Hades; for to them alone is it granted to have true life there; to the rest all there is evil," Sophocles cries out exultantly. And to this Pindar with equal exultation answers: "Happy is he who, having seen these rites goes below the hollow earth; for he knows the end of life and he knows its god-sent beginning." When we read these and other similar statements written by the great or nearly great of the ancient world, by the dramatists and the thinkers, when we picture the magnificent buildings and monuments constructed at Eleusis by great political figures like Peisistratos, Kimon, Perikles, Hadrian, Marcus Aurelius and others, we cannot help but believe that the Mysteries of Eleusis were not an empty, childish affair devised by shrewd priests to fool the peasant and the ignorant, but a philosophy of life that possessed substance and meaning and imparted a modicum of truth to the yearning human soul. That belief is strengthened when we read in Cicero that Athens has given nothing to the world more excellent or divine than the Eleusinian Mysteries. Let us recall again that the rites of Eleusis were held for some two thousand years; that for two thousand years civilized humanity was sustained and ennobled by those rites. Then we shall be able to appreciate the meaning and importance of Eleusis and of the cult of Demeter in the pre-Christian era. When Christianity conquered the Mediterranean world, the rites of Demeter, having perhaps fulfilled their mission to humanity, came to an end. The "bubbling spring" of hope and inspiration that once existed by the Kallichoron well became dry and the world turned to other living sources for sustenance. The cult that inspired the world for so long was gradually forgotten, and its secrets were buried with its last Hierophant.¹²

Finally, a word of caution about the usual generalizations put forth concerning the dichotomy between the mystery religions and the state religions (see pp. 154–155) of antiquity. The argument runs something like this. The formal

state religions were sterile or very soon became so; people's hope and faith lay only in the vivid experience offered by the mysteries. Whatever the general truth of this view, it must be noted that for classical Greece, at any rate, the lines are not so distinct. Ceremonies connected with Demeter at Eleusis are tied securely to the policies of the Athenian state. The *archon basileus* (an Athenian official in charge of religious matters in general) directed the celebrations for Demeter in Athens. The Athenian council as a political body was very much concerned about the festival. The pomp and procession involved are startlingly similar to the pageant connected with the Panathenaic festival in honor of Athena, a civic function, whatever its spiritual import. The "church" at Eleusis and the Athenian state were, to all intents and purposes, one.

The Triumph of Matriarchy

Again and again there appear in mythology variations on the theme of the dominant earth-goddess and her subordinate male lover, who dies and is reborn to ensure the resurrection of the crops and of the souls of mortals. Demeter's name may mean "earth mother," but her myth and that of Persephone introduce a startling and drastic variation of this eternal and universal archetype. The myth's blatant sexuality is replaced by a more refined and purer concept of motherhood and the love between a mother and daughter. In this guise, with nobility and humanity, the mother-goddess and matriarchy sustained their dominance in the ancient world.

Details of the myth continually challenge Zeus' patriarchal power. The abduction of Persephone ordained by the supreme god so that Hades might have a wife and the Underworld might have a queen is depicted not as a divine right but a brutal rape, seen from the point of view of Demeter, who will not accept the status quo and is mighty enough to modify it. Through compromise, both the will of Zeus and the will of Demeter are fulfilled. Demeter shares the love and the person of her daughter with Hades; Hades has his wife; and Persephone attains honor as queen of the Underworld: the mystic cycle of death and rebirth is explained by a myth accommodating a specific matriarchal religious ritual, promising joy in this life and the next.

As we have seen, the Eleusinian mysteries were an inspiring spiritual force and became the one universal mystery religion of the ancient world before Christianity. Indeed, matriarchy was very much alive and well in the patriarchal world of the Greeks and the Romans.

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Homeric Hymn 2	<i>To Demeter</i>
Homeric Hymn 13	<i>To Demeter</i>

Additional Sources

Aristophanes	<i>Thesmophoriazuse</i>
Herodotus	<i>History of the Persian Wars</i> 8.65.1–6 (a mysterious cloud comes from Eleusis)
Ovid	<i>Metamorphoses</i> 5.341–571

Notes

1. That is, “to initiate and observe the holy rite or sacrament.” There appears to be a lacuna after this sentence. The words translated “for the sake of the holy rite” are difficult, and their precise meaning is disputed. The reference must be to an important part of the ceremony of the Eleusinian mysteries, namely, the partaking of a drink called the *Kykeon*. But the nature and significance of the ritual are unknown: was this in any real sense the sharing of a sacrament, an act of communion fraught with mystic significance, or was it merely a token remembrance of these hallowed actions of the goddess?
2. Sixteen of these names are listed among the daughters of Oceanus and Tethys by Hesiod (*Theogony* 346–361); and Melite is a Nereid (246). The poet adds Leucippe, Phaeno, Iache, and Rhodope.
3. The charges against Alcibiades mentioned in the box on p. 292 are indicative of the seriousness of the consequences if the sacred ceremonies were divulged or desecrated in any way.
4. See in particular George E. Mylonas, *Eleusis and the Eleusinian Mysteries* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1961); this remains the best general survey of all the evidence and the inherent archaeological, historical, religious, and philosophical problems. For the priestess of Demeter and Kore at Eleusis, see Joan Breton Connelly, *Portrait of a Priestess* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2007), pp. 64–69.
5. As a place for the celebration of the mysteries (the Greek word is *teletai*), the temple of Demeter is called a *telesterion*.
6. Known as the *Epoptheia*.
7. The Eumolpids (whose ancestor Eumolpus, according to the hymn, received the mysteries from Demeter herself) and the Kerykes.
8. The initiate was the *mystes* and his patron the *mystagogos*.
9. Aristophanes' *Frogs*, 340 ff., gives us some idea of this procession.

10. Another important woman's festival in honor of Demeter, the Haloa, during the season of wine making, celebrated Dionysus as well. There was an abundance of food and drink, and the worshipers were particularly raucous and ribald. See Matthew Dillon, *Girls and Women in Classical Greek Religion* (New York: Routledge, 2002). For a survey of festivals, see H. W. Parke, *Festivals of the Athenians* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1977); also Erika Simon, *Festivals of Attica: An Archaeological Commentary* (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1983).
11. Herodotus (8.65) tells a tale about a mysterious cloud (arising from Eleusis amidst the strains of the mystic hymn to Iacchus) that provided a true omen of future events; in the context, the worship of the mother and the maiden is mentioned. This miracle sets the right tone for elements common to the worship and myths of both Demeter and Dionysus. It is not impossible that the passion of this resurrection-god played some role in the mysteries; Dionysus, too, is close to drama, and drama lies at the essence of the emotional aspects of Eleusinian ritual.
12. Mylonas, *Eleusis and the Eleusinian Mysteries*, pp. 284–285; footnotes are omitted.

For additional resources related to this chapter, go to www.oup.com/us/morford.

Views of the Afterlife: The Realm of Hades

An Ancient Painting of the Underworld

The water appears to be a river, clearly representing Acheron, and there are reeds growing in it and fish. The shapes of the fish are so faintly drawn you would guess they were shadows rather than fish. And on the river there is a boat and at the oars the ferryman.

—PAUSANIAS, *Description of Greece* 10.28.1



Homer's Book of the Dead

The earliest surviving account of the realm of Hades appears in Book 11 of the *Odyssey*. Homer's geographical and spiritual depiction is fundamental to subsequent elaborations and thus deserves to be excerpted at some length. Odysseus is telling the Phaeacians and their king Alcinöus of his visit to the Underworld, where he must consult the seer Tiresias about how to reach Ithaca, his homeland (12–99):

Our ship came to the farthest realm of deep-flowing Oceanus, where the country of the Cimmerians lies shrouded in cloud and mist. Bright Helios never looks down on them with his rays, either when he ascends to starry heaven or returns to earth; but dire night covers these poor mortals. Here we beached our ship, and after putting the animals ashore, we went along the stream of Oceanus until we came to the place that Circe had indicated. Here two of my men, Perimedes and Eurylochus, held the sacrificial victims, and I drew my sharp sword from my side and dug a pit about 18 inches square. Around it I poured a libation to all the dead, first with a mixture of honey and milk, then with sweet wine, and a third time with water; over this I sprinkled white barley. I then supplicated the many strengthless

10



Audio

spirits of the dead, promising that once I had come to Ithaca I should sacrifice, in my own halls, a barren heifer, the very best I had, and heap the sacrificial pyre with the finest things and offer separately to Tiresias alone a jet-black sheep that was outstanding among my flocks.¹ (12–33)

When I had finished entreating the host of the dead with prayers and supplications, I seized the victims and cut their throats, and their dark blood flowed into the pit. Then the souls of the dead who had departed swarmed up from Erebus:² young brides, unmarried boys, old men having suffered much, tender maidens whose hearts were new to sorrow, and many men wounded by bronze-tipped spears and wearing armor stained with blood. From one side and another they gathered about the pit in a multitude with frightening cries. Pale fear took hold of me, and then I urgently ordered my companions to flay the animals which lay slaughtered by the pitiless bronze and burn them and pray to the gods, to mighty Hades and dread Persephone. But I myself drew my sword from my side and took my post and did not allow the strengthless spirits of the dead to come near the blood before I had questioned Tiresias. (34–50) 20

But first the soul of my comrade Elpenor came up, for he had not yet been buried in the wide earth.³ We had left his body in Circe's palace, unwept and unburied, since other toil had oppressed us. I wept at seeing him and pitied him and calling out addressed him with winged words: "Elpenor, how have you come in this gloomy realm? You arrived on foot sooner than I in my black ship." (51–58) 30

Thus I spoke; and he replied with a groan: "Royal son of Laërtes, clever Odysseus, a divine and evil destiny and too much wine were my undoing. When I went to sleep in Circe's palace, I forgot to climb down the long ladder and fell headlong from the roof; my neck was severed from my spine and my soul came down to the realm of Hades.⁴ Since I know that when you leave this house of Hades you will stop with your fine ship at Circe's island of Aeaea, I beseech you by those whom you left behind far away, by your wife and father who took care of you as a child, and by Telemachus, your only son whom you left at home in your palace, do not turn away and go back leaving me unwept and unburied for future time, or I may become the cause of wrathful vengeance from the gods upon you. But burn my body with all the armor that I have and pile up a mound for me on the shore of the gray sea, the grave of an unfortunate man, so that posterity too may know. Do these things for me and plant on the mound the oar with which I rowed alongside my companions while I was alive." (59–78) 40

Thus he spoke. And I addressed him in answer: "My poor friend, I shall accomplish to the full all your wishes." So we two faced each other in sad conversation, I holding my sword over the blood and on the other side the shade of my companion recounting many things. The soul of my dead mother came up next, daughter of great-hearted Autolycus, she who was alive when I went to sacred Ilium. I cried when I saw her and pitied her in my heart. Still, even though I was deeply moved I did not allow her to come near the blood before I had questioned Tiresias. (79–89) 50

Then the soul of Theban Tiresias came up, bearing a golden scepter. He knew me and spoke: "Royal son of Laërtes, clever Odysseus, why, why, my poor fellow, have you left the light of the sun and come to see the dead and their joyless land? But step back from the pit, and hold aside your sharp sword so that I may drink the blood and speak the truth to you." So he spoke; and I drew back my silver-studded sword and thrust it into its sheath. After he had drunk the dark blood, then the noble seer spoke to me.⁵ (90–99) 60

Tiresias then tells Odysseus what destiny has in store for him; after the seer has prophesied, Odysseus asks how he can enable his mother, Anticlea, to recognize him (141–159):

"I see there the soul of my dead mother, and she stays near the blood in silence and has not dared to look at her own son face to face nor speak to him. Tell me, O prince, how may she recognize that I am her son?" Thus I spoke. And he addressed me at once with the answer: "I shall tell you simple directions which you must follow. Any one of the dead you allow to come near the blood will speak to you clearly, but anyone you refuse will go back away from you." With these words the soul of Prince Tiresias went into the home of Hades, after he had uttered his prophecies. (141–151)

But I remained steadfast where I was until my mother came up and drank the dark blood. Immediately then she knew me and in her sorrow spoke winged words: "My son, how have you come, while still alive, below to this gloomy realm which is difficult for the living to behold? For great rivers and terrible waters lie between, first Oceanus which, if one does not have a sturdy ship, he cannot in any way cross on foot." (152–159) 10

Anticlea and Odysseus continue their conversation, questioning each other. Finally, she reveals to her son that it was heartache and longing for him that brought her life to an end. At this Odysseus cannot restrain himself (204–234):

Troubled in spirit I wished to embrace the soul of my dead mother; three times I made the attempt, as desire compelled me, three times she slipped through my hands like a shadow or a dream. Sharp pain welled up from the depths of my heart, and speaking I addressed her with winged words: "O my mother, why do you not stay for me so eager to embrace you, so that we both may throw our arms about each other, even in Hades' realm, and take comfort in chill lamentation? Or has august Persephone conjured up this phantom for me so that I may groan still more in my grief?" (204–214)

Thus I spoke, and she, my lady mother, answered at once: "O my poor child, ill-fated beyond all men; Persephone, daughter of Zeus, does not trick you at all; but this is the doom of mortals when they die, for no longer do sinews hold bones and flesh together, but the mighty power of blazing fire consumes all, as soon as the life breath leaves our white bones and the soul like a dream flutters and flies away. But as quickly as possible make your way back to the light, but understand all these things so that you may in the future tell them to your wife." Thus we two exchanged words; then women came up (for august Persephone compelled them), all of whom were the wives or daughters of noble men. And they gathered all together about the dark blood. But I deliberated how I might speak to each one individually, and upon reflection this seemed to me the best plan. I drew my sharp sword from my sturdy side and did not allow them to drink the dark blood all at the same time. And they came up one by one and each explained her lineage and I questioned them all. (215–234) 10 20

The parade of beautiful women that follows is packed with mythological and genealogical information that has little meaning for us in this context. At the end, Persephone drives away the souls of these illustrious ladies. A lengthy interview follows between Odysseus and Agamemnon, who tells bitterly of his



Closer Look

The Underworld, Apulian red-figure krater by the Underworld painter, ca. 320 B.C.; dimensions not given. This large vase represents many of the myths of the Underworld. In the center, Hades sits enthroned facing Persephone in a small temple. She is crowned and holds a staff; chariot wheels hang from the ceiling, probably the wheels of the chariot in which Hades abducted Persephone. To the left Orpheus plays his lyre, and behind him may be Megara and the children of Heracles. To the right a Fury stands next to a seated judge of the Underworld, before whom is the soul of an old man. In the bottom register Heracles drags off Cerberus, while Hermes points the way. To the left a Fury lashes Sisyphus, and to the right Tantalus, wearing a Phrygian cap, reaches up toward an overhanging cliff. In the upper register appear to be scenes of initiation, and on the neck are the chariots of Helios and Selene, beneath which fishes symbolize the Ocean in which their daily (or nightly) journeys begin and end. (*Staatliche Antikensammlungen und Glyptothek München*)

murder at the hands of his wife, Clytemnestra, and her lover, Aegisthus, and remains suspicious and hostile toward all women. Then the souls of Achilles and Patroclus and the greater Ajax appear. The soul of Achilles addresses Odysseus next (Patroclus does not speak). We must excerpt two portions of their conversation to establish more completely the tone and humanity of Homer's conception. The first reveals Achilles' despair (473–491):

“Royal son of Laërtes, clever and indomitable Odysseus, what still greater exploit have you ingeniously devised? How have you dared to come down to Hades' realm where spirits without body or sense dwell, shadows of mortals worn out by life?” Thus he spoke, and I addressed him in answer, “O Achilles, son of Peleus, by far the mightiest of the Achaeans, I came down to Hades' realm to ask the seer Tiresias if he might tell me some way by which I might return to rocky Ithaca. For I have not yet come near Achaea nor yet reached my homeland, but I always have misfortunes. But no man either before or after is more fortunate than you, Achilles. Previously while you lived, we Argives heaped honors on you equal to those of the gods, and now being in this place you have great power among these shades. So, Achilles, do not be at all distressed, even though you are dead.” (473–486)

Thus I spoke, and he at once addressed me in answer: “Do not speak to me soothingly about death, glorious Odysseus; I should prefer as a slave to serve another man, even if he had no property and little to live on, than to rule over all these dead who have done with life.” (487–491)

Achilles goes on to inquire about his son, Neoptolemus; and when Odysseus has given details of how the boy has proven himself a man worthy of his father, Achilles in his pride feels a surge of joy illumine his gloomy existence (538–544):

The soul of swift-footed Achilles [Odysseus goes on to relate] made its way in great strides over the plain full of asphodel, rejoicing because I said that his son was a renowned hero. Other souls of the dead stood grieving, and each recounted his sorrows. Only the soul of Ajax, son of Telamon, stood apart. (538–544)

Ajax, who committed suicide because Odysseus was awarded the armor of Achilles rather than he, will not respond to Odysseus' appeals (563–600):

Instead he followed the dead spirits into Erebus, where perhaps he might have spoken to me or I to him. But desire in my breast wished to see the souls of the other dead. (563–567)

There I saw Minos, the splendid son of Zeus, sitting with a gold scepter in his hand and pronouncing judgments for the dead, and they sitting and standing asked the king for his decisions within the wide gates of Hades' house. And I saw next the giant hunter Orion, driving together on the plain of asphodel the wild beasts which he himself had killed on the lonely mountains, having in his hand a bronze club that was always unbreakable. And I saw Tityus, son of revered Earth, lying on the ground covering a vast area. Two vultures sitting on either side of him tore into his body and ate at his liver, and his hands could not keep them off. For he had assaulted Leto, the renowned consort of Zeus, as she was going through Panopeus, a city of beautiful dancing places, to Pytho.⁶ (568–581) 10

And also I saw Tantalus enduring harsh sufferings as he stood in a pool that splashed to his chin. He strained to quench his thirst but was not able; for every time the old man leaned eagerly to take a drink, the water was swallowed up and gone and about his feet there was black earth, dried up by some divine power. Tall and leafy trees dangled fruit above his head: pears, pomegranates, apples, sweet figs, and olives, growing in luxuriant profusion. But whenever he reached out to grasp them in his hands, the wind snatched them away to the shadowy clouds.⁷ (582–592) 20

And also I saw Sisyphus enduring hard sufferings as he pushed a huge stone; exerting all his weight with both his hands and feet, he kept shoving it up to the top of the hill. But just when he was about to thrust it over the crest, then its own weight forced it back, and once again the pitiless stone rolled down to the plain. Yet again he put forth his strength and pushed it up; sweat poured from his limbs and dust rose up high about his head. (593–600)

Sisyphus

The greatest exploit of Sisyphus, the son of Aeolus, was outwitting Death (Thanatos) himself. In its simplest form, it is alluded to by the seventh-century poet Alcaeus of Lesbos (frag. 110. 5–10):

For Sisyphus also, the son of Aeolus, thought that he was the cleverest of men to overpower Death. Yet, although he was crafty and crossed swirling Acheron twice (avoiding his destiny), the King [Zeus], son of Cronus, devised labor for him beneath the black earth.

Sisyphus aroused the anger of Zeus by telling the river-god Asopus that Zeus had carried off his daughter Aegina, and Zeus sent Death to carry Sisyphus off. Sisyphus chained Death, and as long as he was bound, no mortals could die. Eventually, Ares freed Death and handed Sisyphus over to him, but before he went down to the Underworld, Sisyphus left instructions with his wife, Merope, not to make the customary sacrifices after his death. When Hades found that no sacrifices were being made, he sent Sisyphus back to remonstrate with Merope. So Sisyphus returned to Corinth and stayed there until he died in advanced old age. It was for his revelation of Zeus' secret that he was punished in the Underworld by having to roll a huge rock uphill only to have it roll down again.

Odysseus next sees the phantom of Heracles—the real Heracles is with his wife, Hebe, among the immortal gods. Heracles tells how he, too, was ill-fated while he lived, performing labors for an inferior master.

Homer's Book of the Dead ends when hordes of the shrieking dead swarm up and Odysseus in fright makes for his ship to resume his journey.

Interpretations of the Homeric Underworld

Countless difficulties beset any interpretation of the Homeric view of the afterlife, many of them linked to the nature of the composition of the *Odyssey* as a whole and of this book in particular. Discrepancies are apparent, and explanations must finally hinge on one's views on the much wider problems of the Homeric question. Does the Book of the Dead reflect different attitudes and concepts put together by one man or by several, at one time or over a period of years—even centuries? Basic to the account, perhaps, is a cult of the dead—seen in the sacrificial ceremonies performed at the trench and in the serious note of moral compulsion to provide burial for one who has died. But as the description proceeds, there is much that is puzzling. Odysseus apparently remains at his post while the souls come up; if so, how does he witness the torments of the sinners and the activities of the heroes described? Are they visions from the pit of blood, or is this episode an awkward addition from a different treatment that had Odysseus actually tour the realm of Hades? Certainly, the section listing the women who come up in a group conveys strongly the feelings of an insertion, written in the style of the Boeotian epic of Hesiod. As the book begins, the stream of Oceanus seems to be the only barrier, but later Anticlea speaks of other rivers to be crossed.

Thus the geography of the Homeric Underworld is vague, and similarly the classification of those who inhabit it is obscurely defined, particularly in terms of the precision that is evident in subsequent literature. Elpenor, among those who first swarm up, may belong to a special group in a special area, but we cannot be sure. Heroes like Agamemnon and Achilles are together, but they do not clearly occupy a separate paradise; the meadow of asphodel they inhabit seems to refer to the whole realm, not to an Elysium such as we find described by Vergil. One senses, rather, that all mortals end up together pretty much in the same place, without distinction. Since Odysseus thinks that Achilles has power among the shades as great as that which he had among the living, perhaps some prerogatives are assigned or taken for granted. A special hell for sinners may be implied (at least they are listed in a group), but it is noteworthy that these sinners are extraordinary indeed, great figures of mythological antiquity who dared great crimes against the gods. Apparently, ordinary mortals do not suffer so for their sins. Homer does not seem to present an afterlife of judgment and reward and punishment, and Minos presumably acts as a judge among the dead, settling their disputes there very much as he did in real life.

The tone and mood of the Homeric afterlife are generally more consistent. Vague and fluttering spirits, with all the pursuits, passions, and prejudices they had while alive, drift aimlessly and joylessly in the gloom; the light and hope and vigor of the upper world are gone. Philosophical and religious thought, shot through with moral earnestness and righteous indignation, will soon bring about sublime and terrifying variations in this picture.

Depicting the Underworld

The Underworld of the ancient Greeks from Homer to the time of Plato was a dim and shadowy place, best described in words. Precise pictures on vases and reliefs were rare, and the Underworld vase, painted some fifty years after Plato's *Republic* and illustrated on p. 358, is an unusually precise image, focusing on the myths of Orpheus, Heracles, and the sinners against the gods. Plato's word-picture gave new definition to the shadows of the Homeric Underworld, preparing the way for Vergil's detailed picture. Only with the Christian expansion of the ancient doctrines of justice and retribution, allied to the ideas of sin and punishment, were artists free to depict an underworld of fire and ice, of devils and exquisite punishments. The *Inferno* of Dante, composed early in the fourteenth century, changed the picture forever, combining the classical myths with medieval doctrines, and preparing the way for the great representations of the Last Judgment such as the fresco by Michelangelo in the Sistine Chapel and innumerable medieval stained glass windows in French and English churches. Their creators would be surprised, and perhaps shocked, to realize that their Christian interpretations were ultimately founded on the pagan myths.



The Last Judgment, by Luca Signorelli (1450–1523); fresco, 1499–1502. In the chapel of San Brizio within the cathedral at Orvieto, Signorelli created his masterpiece, a fresco cycle depicting the end of the world. His work had a profound influence on Michelangelo's Last Judgment in the Sistine Chapel. This section of the work depicts the assembly of the damned as they are brought to hell to be tormented by demons. The decorations on the lower sections of the walls, beneath the larger frescoes such as this one, include portraits of famous poets, including Dante, Vergil, and Ovid, surrounded by grisaille (monochromatic painting using shades of gray) roundels, illustrating stories from their works that touch upon the Underworld—for example, Aeneas, the Sibyl, and the golden bough; Orpheus playing before Pluto and Proserpina; and Heracles capturing Cerberus. When seen in the context of the chapel, these classical poets with their vision of the Underworld appear as the literal foundation of later Christian thinking about the afterlife. (Scala/Art Resource, NY)



Closer Look

Plato's Myth of Er

Plato concludes the last book of his great dialogue, *The Republic*, with the myth of Er. This vision of the afterlife is steeped in religious and philosophical concepts; and although figures from mythology are incorporated, the symbolic and spiritual world depicted is far removed from that of Homer. Addressing Glaucon, Socrates makes this clear as he begins (614b2–616b1):



Audio

I shall not tell a tale like that of Odysseus to Alcinoüs, but instead my story is of a brave man, Er, the son of Armenius, a Pamphylian, who at one time died in war; after ten days, when the bodies—by now decayed—were taken up, his alone was uncorrupted. He was brought home, and on the twelfth day after his death placed on a funeral pyre in preparation for burial. But he came back to life and told what he had seen in the other world. He said that, after his soul had departed, it traveled with many and came to a divine place, in which there were two openings in the earth next to each other, and opposite were two others in the upper region of the sky. (614b2–614c3)

In the space between these four openings sat judges who passed sentence: the just they ordered to go to the right through one of the openings upward in the sky, after they had affixed their judgments in front of them; the unjust they sent to the left through one of the downward openings, bearing on their backs indications of all that they had done; to Er, when he approached, they said that he must be a messenger to human beings about the afterlife and commanded him to listen and watch everything in this place. (614c3–614d3) 10

To be sure, he saw there the souls, after they had been judged, going away through the opening either in the heaven or in the earth, but from the remaining two openings he saw some souls coming up out of the earth, covered with dust and dirt, and others descending from the second opening in the sky, pure and shining. And they kept arriving and appeared as if they were happy indeed to return after a long journey to the plain that lay between. Here they encamped as though for a festival, and mutual acquaintances exchanged greetings; those who had come from the earth and those from the sky questioned one another. The first group recounted their experiences, weeping and wailing as they recalled all the various things they had suffered and seen in their journey under the earth, which had lasted one thousand years; the others from the sky told in turn of the happiness they had felt and sights of indescribable beauty. (614d3–615a4) 20

O Glaucon, it would take a long time to relate everything. But he did say that the essential significance was this: everyone had to suffer an appropriate penalty for each and every sin ten times over, in retribution for the number of times and the number of persons he had wronged; that is, he must make one full payment once every hundred years (since this is considered the span of human life) so that he might pay in full for all his wrongs, tenfold in one thousand years. For example, if any were responsible for the deaths of many or betrayed and enslaved cities or armies or were guilty of any other crime, they would suffer torments ten times over for all these sins individually; but on the other hand, if they had done good deeds and were just and holy, in the same proportion they were given a worthy reward. About those who died immediately after birth and those who had lived a short time he said other things not worth mentioning. (615a4–615c2) 30 40

He described still greater retribution for honor or dishonor toward gods and parents and for murder. He told how he was near one spirit who asked another where Ardiaeus the Great was. This Ardiaeus had been tyrant in a city of Pamphylia a thousand years before this time, and he was said to have killed his aged parents and older brother and to have committed many other unholy deeds. The reply was that he had not come and would not come back to the plain. For to be sure this was one of the terrifying sights that we witnessed. (615c2–615d4)

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When we were near the mouth and about to come up, after experiencing everything else, we suddenly saw Ardiaeus and others, most of whom were tyrants, but there were also some ordinary persons who had committed great wrongs. They all thought that they would at last ascend upward, but the mouth would not let them; instead it gave forth a roar, whenever any who were so incurable in their wickedness or had not paid sufficient penalty attempted to come up. Then indeed wild men, fiery of aspect, who stood by and understood the roar, seized some of them and led them away, but they bound Ardiaeus and the others, head, hand, and foot, threw them down, and flayed them; they dragged them along the road outside the mouth combing their flesh like wool with thorns, making clear to others as they passed the reason for the punishment and that they were being led away to be hurled down to Tartarus. (615d4–616a4)

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Of all the many and varied terrors that happened to them there, by far the greatest for each was that he might hear the roar as he came up, and when there was silence each ascended with the utmost joy. The judgments then were such as these: punishments for some and again rewards for others in due proportion.

The souls who have completed their cycle of one thousand years spend seven days on the plain and then proceed on another journey, accompanied by Er. Four days later they arrive at a place from which they behold a beam of light that extends like a pillar through all of heaven and earth. After another day's journey, they can see that this light provides as it were a bond or chain to hold the universe together; from this chain of light extends the spindle of Necessity (*Ananke*) by which all the revolving spheres are turned. The next section of the myth presents a difficult, cosmological explanation of the universe, with its circles of fixed stars and revolving planets, the earth being at the center.⁸

Then Plato's account of Er, as Socrates relates it, continues with a description of the harmony of the spheres (617b4–621d3):

The spindle turned on the knees of Necessity. A Siren was perched aloft each of the circles and borne along with it, uttering a single sound on one musical note; from all eight came a unified harmony. Round about at equal distances sat three others, each on a throne, the Fates (*Moirai*), daughters of Necessity, in white robes with garlands on their heads, Lachesis, Clotho, and Atropos, singing to the music of the Sirens: Lachesis of the past, Clotho of the present, and Atropos of the future. Clotho touches with her right hand the outside circle of the spindle and helps turn it; with her left Atropos moves the inner circles in the same way, and Lachesis touches and moves both, alternating with each hand. (617b4–617d1)

10

Immediately after the souls arrived, they had to approach Lachesis. First of all, a prophet arranged them in order; and then, after taking from the knees of



Audio

Lachesis lots and examples of lives, he mounted a lofty platform and spoke: “Hear the word of Lachesis, maiden daughter of Necessity. Ephemeral souls, this is the beginning of another cycle of mortal life fraught with death. A divinity will not allot himself to you, but you will choose your divinity.⁹ Let one who has drawn the first lot choose a life, which will be his by necessity. Virtue is without master; each man has a greater or lesser share, insofar as he honors or dishonors her. The blame belongs to the one who makes the choice; god is blameless.” (617d1–617e5)

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With these words, he cast the lots among them all, and each picked up the one that fell near him. Only Er was not allowed to participate. It was clear to each when he had picked up his lot what number he had drawn. Next he placed the examples of lives on the ground in front of them, many more than those present and of every kind; lives of all living creatures and all human beings. Among them lives of tyrants, some complete, others cut short and ending in poverty, exile, and destitution. There were lives of illustrious men, renowned for form and beauty or strength and physical achievement, others for family and the virtues of their ancestors; in the same way were lives of unknown or disreputable men; and so it was for women. But the disposition of the soul was not included because with its choice of another life it too of necessity became different, but the other qualities were mixed with one another, wealth and poverty, sickness and health, and intermediate states. (617e6–618b6)

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REINCARNATION IMPOSES A DIFFICULT CHOICE

Herein to be sure, as it seems, my dear Glaucon, lies all the risk; therefore each one of us must seek to find and understand this crucial knowledge; he must search if he can hear of and discover one who will make him capable of knowing; he must distinguish the good life from the wicked and choose always in every situation from the possibilities the better course, taking into account all that has now been said. He must know how these qualities, individually or combined, affect virtue in a life; what beauty mixed with poverty or wealth achieves in terms of good and evil, along with the kind of state of soul that it inspires; and what high and low birth, private status, public office, strength, weakness, intelligence, stupidity, and all such qualities, inherent or acquired, achieve in combination with one another, so that after deliberation he may be able to choose from all of these between the worse and better life, looking only to the effect upon the nature of his soul. (618b6–618d7)

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By the worse life I mean that leading the soul to become more unjust; by the better, that leading it to become more just. All other considerations he will ignore. For we have seen that this is the most crucial choice for a human being living or dead. Indeed, one must cling to this conviction even when he comes to the realm of Hades, so that here, just as in the other world, he may not be overwhelmed by wealth and similar evils and succumb to acts like those of a tyrant, committing many incurable evils, and besides suffering still greater ones himself, and so that he may know how to choose a life that follows the mean in such circumstances, and to avoid the excess in either direction, both in this life and in every future life, as far as he is able. For in this way a person becomes most fortunate and blessed. (618d7–619b1)

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Then indeed Er, the messenger from the afterlife, reported that the prophet spoke as follows: “Even for the one who comes last, there lies a life that is

desirable and not evil, if he chooses intelligently and lives it unflinchingly. Let
 not the one who chooses first be careless, nor the last discouraged." After he
 had spoken, the one who had drawn the first lot immediately went up and chose
 the most extreme tyranny, and he made his choice out of senselessness and
 greed and did not look closely at everything, and he did not notice that his
 life entailed the fate of eating his own children and other evils. And when he
 examined his choice at leisure, he beat his breast and lamented that he had not
 abided by the warnings of the prophet. For he did not accept the responsibility
 for these evils, but he blamed fate and the gods and everything rather than
 himself. He was one of those who had come down from the sky and had lived
 his previous life in a city with an orderly political constitution and adopted virtue
 through habit rather than wisdom. (619b2–619d1) 60 70

Generally speaking, the number of those who came down from the sky and
 were caught in this kind of predicament was not small, since they were un-
 trained in suffering. But many of those from earth, since they had themselves
 suffered and seen others suffer, did not make their choice on impulse. Because
 of this and because of the chance of the lot, for many souls there occurred a
 change from an evil to a good fate or the reverse. For if one always pursues
 wisdom with all his strength each time he takes a life in the world, and if the
 lot of choosing does not fall to him among the last, it is likely, from all that has
 been reported, that not only will he be happy in life but also his journey after
 death from the plain and back will not be under the earth and hard, but easy and
 upward to the sky. (619d1–619e5) 80

Er said that to watch each soul as he chose his life was a worthwhile sight,
 piteous, laughable, and wondrous. For the most part, they made their choices
 on the basis of their experiences in their previous lives. He saw the soul that
 had been that of Orpheus choose the life of a swan through hatred of the
 female sex because of his death at their hands, not wishing to be born again of
 woman. And he saw the soul of Thamyras select the life of a nightingale, and
 a swan decide to change to the life of a human, and other musical creatures
 make similar decisions. The soul that drew the twentieth lot chose the life of a
 lion; this was the soul of Ajax, son of Telamon, avoiding a human life because
 he remembered the judgment concerning Achilles' armor. After him came the
 soul of Agamemnon; he too through hatred of the human race because of his
 sufferings changed to the life of an eagle. The choice of the soul of Atalanta fell
 in the middle of the proceedings; she saw great honors attached to the life of a
 male athlete and took it, not being able to pass it by. He saw after her the soul
 of Epeus, the son of Panopeus, assuming the nature of a craftswoman, and far
 away among the last the soul of the ridiculous Thersites taking the form of an
 ape. (619e6–620c3) 90

In his fated turn, the soul of Odysseus, who had drawn the last lot, went to
 choose; remembering his former toils, he sought to be free from ambition; he
 looked a long time and with difficulty found the quiet life of an ordinary man
 lying somewhere disregarded by the others and, when he saw it, he made his
 choice gladly and said that he would have done the same thing even if the first
 lot had fallen to him. In the same way, souls of wild animals exchanged forms or
 entered human beings, the unjust changing to savage beasts, the just to tame
 ones; and all kinds of combinations occurred. (620c3–620d5) 100

When all the souls had chosen lives, they proceeded in order according to
 their lots to Lachesis. She gave to each the divinity (*daimon*) he had chosen to

accompany him as a guardian for his life and to fulfill his choices. This divinity 110
 first led the soul to Clotho, under her hand as it turned the revolving spindle, to
 ratify the fate each had chosen after drawing his lot. He touched her and then
 led the soul to the spinning of Atropos, thus making the events on the thread of
 destiny unalterable. From here without turning back they went under the throne
 of Necessity and passed beyond it. When all the souls and their guardian divini-
 ties had done this, they proceeded together to the plain of the river of forgetful-
 ness (Lethe) through a terrible and stifling heat. For it was devoid of trees and
 all that the earth grows. (620d6–621a4)

Now that it was evening, they encamped by the river of forgetfulness, 120
 whose water no container can hold. It is necessary for all to drink a fixed
 amount of the water, but some do not have the wisdom to keep from drinking
 more than this amount. As one drinks, one becomes forgetful of everything.
 In the middle of the night when they were asleep, there was thunder and
 an earthquake, and then suddenly just like shooting stars they were borne
 upward, each in a different direction to his birth. Er himself was prevented
 from drinking the water. He does not know where and how he returned to his
 body, but suddenly opening his eyes he saw that he was lying on the funeral
 pyre at dawn. (621a4–621b7)

Thus, O Glaucon, the myth has been preserved and has not perished. We 130
 should be saved if we heed it, and we shall cross the river of forgetfulness well
 and not contaminate our souls. But if we all agree in believing the soul is im-
 mortal and capable of enduring all evils and all good, we shall always cling to the
 upward path and in every way pursue justice with wisdom, so that we may be in
 loving reconciliation with ourselves and the gods, and so that when we carry off
 the prizes of justice, just like victors in the games collecting their rewards, both
 while we are here and in the thousand-year journey we have described, we may
 fare well. (621b8–621d3)

This vision of an afterlife, written in the fourth century B.C., comes from vari-
 ous sources about which we can only conjecture. We must also allow for the
 inventive genius of Plato himself in terms of his own philosophy. The numeric
 intervals (e.g., the journey of a thousand years) are reminiscent of Pythagoras
 and the belief in the transmigration of the soul; reward and punishment, with
 ultimate purification, is usually identified as Orphic. Since this myth of revela-
 tion concludes *The Republic* with proof of divine immortality, problems abound
 in connection with its precise interpretation. How much was intended to be ac-
 cepted literally? Is Er's story an allegory filled with profound symbols hiding the
 universal truths it wishes to disclose?

In his *Phaedo*, Plato provides another vision of the afterlife in which he ex-
 plains (114b–c) how true philosophers eventually are released from the cycle of
 reincarnation. Those who have lived a life of exceptional holiness and purify
 themselves sufficiently through their pursuit of philosophy live entirely as souls
 in the hereafter in beautiful dwellings, which are not easy to describe.

For the purposes of our sketch of the development of the Greek and Roman
 concept of the afterlife, it is important to stress that a heaven and a hell are
 clearly depicted for the soul of every mortal; and in addition to the upward
 and downward paths that must be traversed, special tormentors exist, as does a
 special place of torment (Tartarus) in which the greatest sinners are placed for-
 ever.¹⁰ In such a conception lies the mythical and biblical basis for the mystery

religions of antiquity, whether their god be Demeter or Dionysus and their prophet Orpheus or Plato.¹¹ Ties with Christian sentiments are not hard to see, despite the obvious differences. More specific links are provided by the early Christian identification of Er as an ancestor of St. Joseph and by the fact that these early Christians, in their championship of free will, seized upon the admonition of Lachesis: "This blame belongs to him who makes the choice; god is blameless."

Vergil's Book of the Dead

In Book 6 of the *Aeneid*, Vergil paints his sad and prophetic picture of the Underworld in shadowy halftones fraught with tears and pathos. His sources are eclectic, but his poetic vision is personal and unique. Despite the centuries of oral and written tradition and the Roman chauvinism of his depiction, Homeric and Platonic elements are often still distinctly evident. At Cumae, in Italy, the Sibyl, prophetess of Apollo, tells Aeneas what the requirements are to visit his father in the realm of Hades. He must get a golden bough, sacred to Proserpine (i.e., Persephone), and bury his comrade, Misenus. It is easy to descend to the Underworld; the task is to retrace one's steps to the upper air, which only a special few have managed. While his men are preparing a funeral pyre for Misenus, Aeneas goes in search of the bough (186–204):

As Aeneas gazed at the vast woods, it happened that he uttered a prayer: "If only the golden bough would show itself to me in so immense a forest. For the priestess told all that was true—alas, too true—about your need for burial, Misenus." At that moment, as it happened, twin doves came flying from the sky under his very eyes and settled on the green ground. Then the great hero recognized his mother's birds and in his joy prayed: "Be leaders, if there is some way, and direct your course to the grove where the branch rich in gold shades the fertile earth; O goddess mother do not fail me in this crisis." (186–197)

Thus he spoke and stopped in his tracks, watching what sign they gave and what course they took. They would stop to feed and then fly ahead, always permitting Aeneas to keep them in sight as he followed. When they approached the foul odor coming up from Lake Avernus, they quickly flew higher; and gliding through the liquid air the doves settled down together on the longed-for tree, where the tawny gleam of gold flickered through the branches. (197–204)

Aeneas eagerly breaks off the golden bough; after the funeral rites for Misenus have been completed, he takes the bough to the Sibyl (237–332):

There was a deep and rocky cave with a huge yawning mouth sheltered by the black lake and the darkness of the forest; no birds at all were able to wing their way overhead, so great and foul an exhalation poured up to the vault of heaven from the lake. Its name, Avernus, deriving from the Greek, means "birdless." Here first of all the priestess set four black bullocks and poured wine over their heads; between their horns she cut the tips of bristles and placed them on the sacred fire as first libations, calling aloud on Hecate, who holds power both in the sky above and in the depths of Erebus. Attendants applied their knives and caught the warm blood in bowls. Aeneas himself slaughtered with



Audio

Aeneas and the Sibyl in the Underworld (1600), by Jan Brueghel the Elder (1568–1625); oil on canvas, $14 \frac{1}{4} \times 10 \frac{1}{2}$ in. Aeneas strides along holding his sword (useless against the powers of the Underworld) and the golden bough, which he must offer to Persephone before he can enter the Elysian Fields. Behind are the lurid fires of Tartarus, and on either side are monsters and sinners enduring or awaiting punishment. (*Szépművészeti Museum, Budapest, Hungary*)



Closer Look



his sword a black-fleeced lamb for Night, the mother of the Eumenides, and her great sister, Earth; and for you, Proserpine, a barren cow; then he built an altar in the night for the Stygian king and placed on the flames the whole carcasses of bulls, pouring rich oil over their entrails. Lo, at the first rays of the rising sun, the ground rumbled and the wooded ridges began to move and she-dogs appeared howling through the gloom as the goddess approached from the Underworld. (237–258) 10

The Sibyl cried: "Keep back, keep back, you who are unhallowed; withdraw completely from this grove. But you, Aeneas, enter the path and seize your sword from its sheath. Now there is need for courage and a stout heart." This much she spoke and threw herself furiously into the cave. Aeneas, without fear, 20
matched the steps of his leader as she went. (258–263)

You gods who rule over spirits, silent shades, depths of Chaos, Phlegethon, and vast realms of night and silence, let it be right for me to speak what I have heard; by your divine will let me reveal things buried deep in earth and blackness.

They went, dim figures in the shadows of the lonely night, through the empty homes and vacant realms of Dis, as though along a road in woods by the dim and treacherous light of the moon, when Jupiter has clouded the sky in darkness, and black night has robbed objects of their color. At the entrance itself, 30
in the very jaws of Orcus, Grief and avenging Cares have placed their beds; here dwell pale Diseases, sad Old Age, Fear, evil-counseling Hunger, foul Need, forms terrible to behold, and Death and Toil; then Sleep, the brother of Death, and Joys evil even to think about, and opposite on the threshold, death-dealing War, the iron chambers of the Eumenides, and insane Discord, her hair entwined with snakes and wreaths of blood. (268–281)

In the middle, a huge and shady elm spreads its boughs, aged arms in which empty Dreams are said to throng and cling beneath all the leaves. There were also many different forms of beasts and monsters: Centaurs had their haunt in the doorway, Scyllas with twofold form, hundred-handed Briareus, 40
the creature of Lerna hissing dreadfully, the Chimaera armed with flames, Gorgons, Harpies, and the shade of triple-bodied Geryon. Suddenly Aeneas, startled by fear, snatched his sword and threatened them with his drawn blade as they approached. If his wise companion had not warned that these insubstantial lives without body flitted about with but the empty shadow of a form, he would have rushed in and smitten the shades with his weapon for nothing. (282–294)

From here is a path that leads to the waters of Acheron, a river of Tartarus, whose seething flood boils turbid with mud in vast eddies and pours all its sand into the stream of Cocytus.¹² A ferryman guards these waters, Charon, horrifying 50
in his terrible squalor; a mass of white beard lies unkempt on his chin, his eyes glow with a steady flame, and a dirty cloak hangs from his shoulders by a knot. He pushes his boat himself by a pole, tends to the sails, and conveys the bodies across in his rusty craft; he is now older, but for a god old age is vigorous and green. Here a whole crowd poured forth and rushed down to the bank: mothers and men, the bodies of great-souled heroes finished with life, boys and unmarried girls, young men placed on the pyres before the eyes of their parents, as many as the leaves that drop and fall in the forest at the first cold of autumn or as the birds that flock to land from the stormy deep, when winter puts them to flight across the sea and sends them to sunny lands. They stood 60
pleading to be the first to cross and stretched out their hands in longing for the farther shore. The grim boatman accepted now these and now those, but he drove others back and kept them at a distance from the sandy shore. (295–316)

Aeneas, who was moved by the tumult, asked in wonder: "Tell me, O virgin Sibyl, the meaning of this gathering at the river. What do these souls seek? By what distinction do some retire from the bank, while others are taken across the

Cerberus (1825–1827), by William Blake (1757–1827); watercolor on board, 9 ½ × 13 in. Blake worked on his illustrations of Dante's *Divine Comedy* for the last two years of his life, leaving 102 drawings at his death, of which 72 were for *Inferno*. This is the first of his two drawings of Cerberus, the guardian of the third circle of Hell, the place of the gluttons, in the sixth canto of *Inferno*. Blake represents Dante's description of the fistlike paws of Cerberus, with which he seizes sinners. Cerberus' middle head looks toward Vergil on the right, behind whom the faint figure of Dante waits to throw handfuls of earth into the monster's mouth. (*Tate, London/Art Resource, NY*)



murky stream?” The aged priestess answered him briefly as follows: “Son of Anchises, and most certainly a descendant of the gods, you see the deep pools of Cocytus and the marshes of the Styx, the river by which the gods fear to swear falsely. This one group here consists of those who are poor and unburied.¹³ The ferryman is Charon. The others whom he takes across are those who have been buried. Charon is not allowed to transport them over the hoarse-sounding waters to the dread shore if their bones have not found rest in proper burial; but a hundred years they wander and flit about this bank before they come back at last to the longed-for waters to be admitted to the boat.” The son of Anchises stopped in his tracks and stood thinking many thoughts, pitying in his heart the inequity of the fate of human beings. (317–332)

70

Among those who have not received burial, Aeneas sees his helmsman Palinurus, who had fallen overboard on their voyage from Africa; he managed to reach the coast of Italy, but once he came ashore tribesmen killed him. The interview is reminiscent of the exchange between Odysseus and Elpenor in human emotion and religious sentiment. The Sibyl comforts Palinurus with the prediction that he will be buried by a neighboring tribe. The book continues (384–449):

Aeneas and the Sibyl proceed on their way and approach the river. When the ferryman spied them from his post by the river Styx, coming through the silent grove and turning their steps toward the bank, he challenged them first with unprovoked abuse: “Whoever you are who approach our river in arms, explain why you have come but answer from there, do not take another step. This is the place of the shades, of sleep and drowsy night; it is forbidden to carry living